# On Reincarnation. Part I

## Madhyamaka – Prasangika

school of the Middle Way

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**The Seven-Point Cause-and-Effect Technique:**

1. Recognising all sentient beings as your mothers.
2. Remembering their kindness and care.
3. Developing the wish to repay their kindness.
4. Cultivating unconditional love for all beings.
5. Developing compassion — the wish to free all from suffering.
6. Taking responsibility — the arising of the supreme intention.
7. As the natural result of this process — the generation of Bodhicitta.

In the Gelug school tradition, the method known as the **"Seven-Point Cause-and-Effect Technique"** is used to understand the continuity of the stream of being and the phenomenon of reincarnation.

This method is aimed not only at comprehending the nature of reincarnation but also at realising the deep interconnectedness with all sentient beings, cultivating compassion, and ultimately taking the **Bodhisattva Vow** — the commitment to attain the state of Buddha-hood (ultimate bodhicitta, omniscience) for the benefit of all living beings. The method originates from a living lineage of Buddhist philosophical transmission. This presentation is an interpretation and systematisation based on reflection, study, and personal experience. In particular, we express deep gratitude to **His Holiness the 14th Dalai Lama** and **Venerable Geshe Jampa Tinley**.

### Establishing the Existence of Past and Future Lives

First and foremost, we must arrive at an inner conviction that past and future lives exist — and moreover, that past lives are countless.

### Thesis: Without a cause, there is no result.

Let us pose a fundamental question:

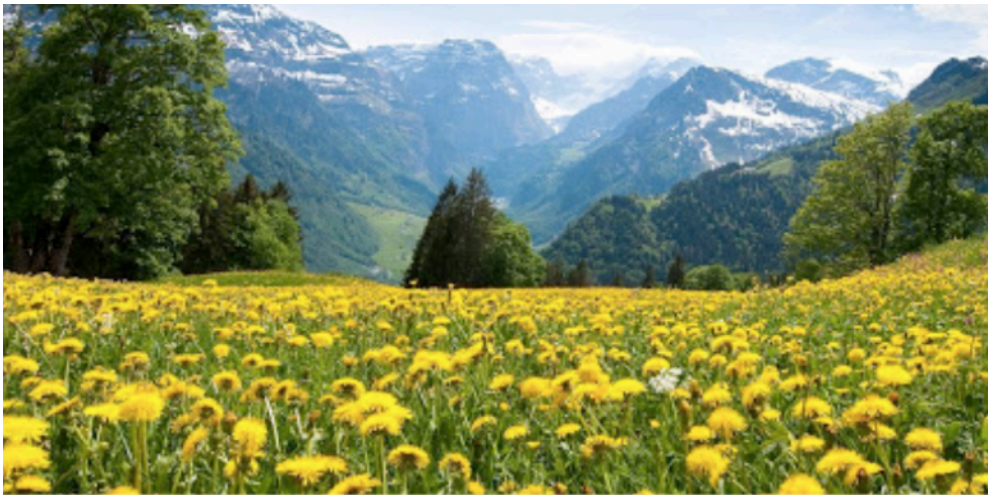
**Does the first moment of our consciousness depend on a cause?**

According to the law of the excluded middle, there are only two logically permissible options: yes — it does depend, or no — it does not depend. There is no third alternative.

**YES** (If the first moment of a child's consciousness in the mother's womb **arose due to a cause)**, then it is not truly the *first* moment of consciousness — something must have preceded it.

**NO** (If the first moment of a child's consciousness in the mother's womb **arose without a cause)**, then consciousness would be unchanging and non-functional. This contradicts reality.

If yellow flowers could appear without a cause, they would grow everywhere.
But why do they grow in some places and not in others?
Because they sprout where their seeds have been sown.Rain may fall everywhere, but yellow flowers will only grow where there is both soil and seed.
If the seed were irrelevant, flowers would appear wherever it rains.
Therefore, the seed is the **cause**, and the rain is the **condition**.



Sometimes people are lucky, and sometimes they are not. If luck arose without a cause, then everyone would be lucky all the time. But we clearly see this is not the case.

Therefore, luck depends on a cause.Just as a seed gives rise to a flower, luck arises from wholesome causes — kind thoughts, good intentions, and virtuous actions.These are the seeds of positive karma that lead you to your own good fortune.

If something does not depend on a cause, we would not be able to explain why it is present in one place and absent in another.



The first seven points of the cause-and-effect technique are aimed at developing a deep understanding that everything arises from a cause. This helps eliminate the false belief in randomness. Randomness is neither empirically nor logically justified.

**If there is a cause — the result will inevitably manifest.**
**And if there is no cause — how could a result possibly arise?**

Now let us consider all possible phenomena. They can be divided into **two main categories:**

- **Permanent (non-functional) phenomena** — do not depend on a cause and do not change. An example of this is **space**.
- **Impermanent (functional) phenomena** — depend on a cause, change in response to conditions, and perform a function.

## Thesis: If consciousness did not function, it would be unchanging — like space.

If consciousness did not function, we would be incapable not only of feeling — no pain, no joy — but of perceiving anything at all.Yet we clearly see that consciousness is functional: sometimes we are fully absorbed in visual perception; at other times — with eyes closed — we pick up only sounds, warmth, taste, or touch.

The constant shift in mental states tells us that consciousness is not a fixed "something," but a **functional phenomenon**.Buddhist logic not only recognises that consciousness arises in dependence on causes, but also affirms the existence of a **substantial cause** — a foundational basis from which consciousness truly originates.

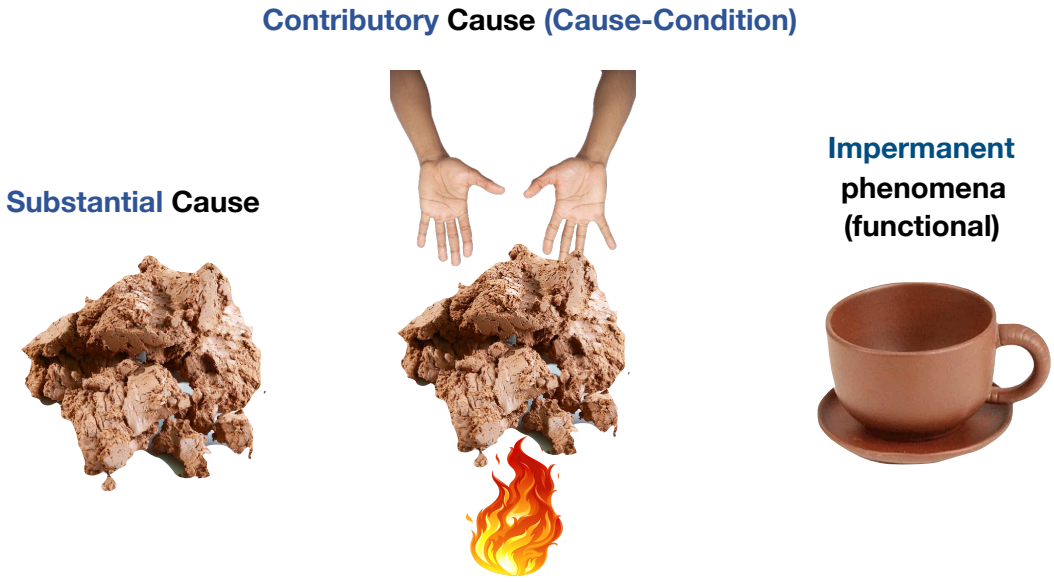
**It is important to distinguish between:**

Depending on the object and conditions, different types of consciousness arise:
— **Visual consciousness** arises in dependence on form and the eye,
— **Auditory consciousness** arises from sound and the ear,
— **Gustatory consciousness** arises from taste and the tongue,
— **Tactile consciousness** arises from touch and the body.

All types of consciousness depend on the object of perception and the corresponding sense organ. This is known as the **external causality of consciousness** — it is what causes the shifts between different forms of consciousness: from visual to auditory, from gustatory to tactile, and so on.

Consciousness does not arise from matter, from a sense organ, or from the object — it arises from **consciousness** itself. That is why the stream of mind is **uninterrupted**: there exists no cause capable of ending consciousness. If such a cause did exist, then consciousness would necessarily come to an end.

Note:
Substantial Cause (Tib. *nyer len*, Skt. *upādāna*) — a cause that fully transforms into the result.




A **clay cup**: its **substantial cause** is **clay**. The **human hands** that shaped the cup, and the **fire** that hardened it, served as **conditioning causes**. At the moment the cup came into existence, the lump of clay **ceased to exist in its original form**. The clay **became** the clay cup. This illustrates that the **substantial cause cannot exist simultaneously with its result**. Once the result arises, the cause — in the form it previously had — no longer exists. The clay is no longer just clay, but it continues to exist in the form of its result — the clay cup. To continue our analysis, we must now return to the two categories of phenomena mentioned earlier: **functional (changing)** and **non-functional (unchanging, permanent)**.

Since non-functional phenomena — by definition — do not change and are not dependent on causes,
they are **not subject to further cause-and-effect analysis**.

Therefore, in the next stage of contemplation, we set them aside and focus only on **functional phenomena** — those that **arise, change, and cease depending on causes**.

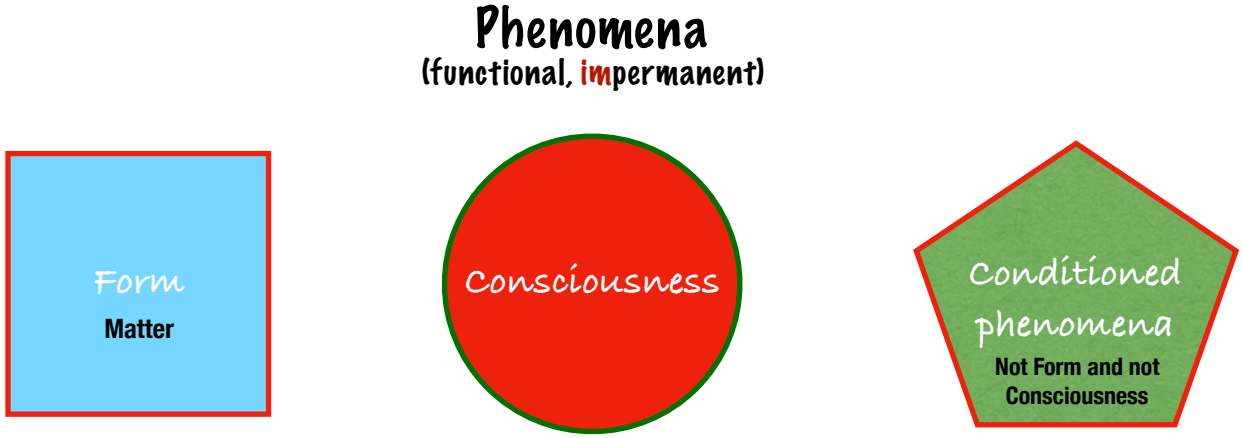
Phenomena
(functional, impermanent)

~~Non-Phenomena~~
(unfunctional, permanent)

We have previously examined and established the following:
The **first moment of consciousness** in a child within the mother's womb **cannot arise without a cause**. **Consciousness** is an **impermanent, functional phenomenon**, whose **substantial cause** can only be another moment of consciousness. All **non-phenomena** or **permanent, non-functional phenomena** have been excluded from this analysis, as they **cannot serve as the cause** for the arising of the first moment of consciousness in the womb. This entire category is therefore eliminated from further reasoning, as it is unsuitable for explaining the origin of consciousness.

In order to prove that consciousness can arise only from consciousness, we must demonstrate that it cannot arise from any other kind of cause. As we continue our analysis, we remain strictly within the domain of **impermanent (functional) phenomena** — since only these are capable of producing effects and therefore are valid candidates for being causes.

According to Buddhist classification, these phenomena are conventionally divided into **three main categories**:




**Form (rūpa)** — refers to everything that has a material nature.
Form includes not only physical matter, but also the sense organs, perceivable objects, and even subtle forms. It is a kind of substance that occupies space, can be tangible, visible, etc.

**Consciousness (vijñāna)** — is clarity and awareness, the ability to perceive, distinguish, know, and feel. Consciousness itself is not form and does not consist of matter. It is a separate category of phenomena, possessing its own substantial cause.

**Compositional Factors (saṃskāra)** — are a broad group of functional phenomena that are neither form nor consciousness, yet they play an important role in the arising and maintenance of phenomena.

Among the many elements that fall under the category of compositional factors, **memory** holds a special place.

**Memory is a functional phenomenon, neither form nor consciousness, but it plays a key role in creating the perceived continuity of the self.**

It is memory that maintains the connection between bodily form and consciousness, forming the basis for the experience of **"I am this"** — the experience of oneself as a person existing in time, with a history, a biography, and a character.

Memory does not possess a substantial nature — it is identical neither to the body nor to the mind. Yet it **structures the stream**: it links moments of experience into a conditionally continuous chain, and thereby becomes the **foundation of the phenomenon of personality**.

## Analysis of the Hypothesis of a Material Substantial Cause of Consciousness:

*Hypothesis:*
Let us suppose that **form** (a material substance), such as DNA, genes, and so on — which are indeed the cause of the child's body — are **also the substantial cause of the child's consciousness**.

*Implication of the Definition:*
If genes and DNA are the substantial cause of consciousness, then consciousness must be composed of genes and DNA. But this is impossible, because consciousness does not have a material nature. It does not occupy physical space, nor does it have form, weight, or density. Qualities of consciousness such as anger, joy, and attachment cannot be reduced to physical structures like genes.

*Additional argument:*
If consciousness were truly material, then removing or altering its qualities — such as anger, fear, or compassion — would be a matter of mechanical intervention: one would simply need to extract or modify a material component. But this does not correspond to reality: changing states of consciousness requires working with the mind, attention, and view — not with the body or DNA molecules.

## Conclusion:

**Matter (form)** cannot be the **substantial cause** of consciousness. It may serve as a **condition** (conditioning cause) for **Consciousness.**

**Consciousness** is the **substantial cause** of **Consciousness.**

**Conditioned phenomena** cannot be the substantial cause of **Consciousness.**

Let us consider two possible alternatives (excluding the option of arising without a cause) for the origin of the first moment of consciousness in the mother's womb:

### 1.The child's consciousness arises from the mother's consciousness

If the child's consciousness arose from the mother's consciousness as its substantial cause, then, according to the definition, the mother's consciousness would have to cease at the moment of its "transmission." This is similar to how clay ceases to be clay in the form it previously existed, becoming a cup — its result. However, in reality: The mother's consciousness does not disappear at the birth of the child.

Therefore, the mother's consciousness cannot be the substantial cause of the child's consciousness. The consciousness of one person does not give rise to the consciousness of another as a substantial cause. The child's consciousness must originate from another source — not from the body and not from the mother's consciousness.

### 2. The child's consciousness is the result of the preceding stream of that very same consciousness

Consciousness does not arise from matter, from another person's consciousness (such as the mother's), or from nothing. Nor does it arise randomly or without cause — it manifests as a continuous stream. According to the previously established logic, the **substantial cause** of consciousness can only be **consciousness**.

Therefore, the first moment of consciousness in the womb cannot be caused by the body, matter, or external conditions — its cause is the consciousness that existed before it. Thus, the **last moment of consciousness at death** and the **first moment of consciousness at birth** are links in the same unbroken chain. This chain is the **stream of consciousness**, which — having no external substantial cause — can only continue **from itself**, carrying on through death into the next rebirth.

No other basis can give rise to new consciousness except for preceding consciousness. Therefore, each new birth is not the beginning of a new consciousness, but the continuation of the **same stream**, which changes bodies but maintains its continuity. This makes it clear why all beings you can observe **have, at some point, been your mothers**.

**Conclusion:**

The presented analysis shows that the logic of the Madhyamaka-Prasangika school allows for a consistent and rigorous demonstration of the **continuity of the individual stream of consciousness** and, as a consequence, the **reality of the phenomenon of reincarnation**. We see that consciousness cannot be produced by matter, external conditions, or another consciousness. The only non-contradictory possibility is that **consciousness arises only from consciousness**, as the result of its own preceding

Thus, a new birth is not the beginning of a new consciousness, but the continuation of the previous stream. The change of body does not break the inner causality.

**Memory**, as a functional phenomenon, remains connected to the former body, while the **stream of consciousness** carries into the new birth the results of karmic causes that ripened in the previous stream.

**This work, as the first part, is an offering of respect to the tradition that frees from false views through logical analysis. I bow, filled with reverence, before Madhyamaka-Prasangika as the authentic Teacher.**

Its rigorous reasoning and depth make it possible to lay a solid foundation necessary for the correct understanding of the logic of rebirth. In the second part, we will present an entirely new, direct, and axiomatic proof of reincarnation.

Our next work — ***"The Axiomatic System of Implicative Reincarnation of a Living Conditioned Being"*** — will be based on logic that does not require prior familiarity with Buddhist categories, yet fully aligns with them in essence and spirit.

We are convinced that only on the basis of a rigorously constructed foundation can a proof be presented that satisfies both the philosopher and the practitioner. Everything begins with a cause. And if we have realized that **consciousness can arise only from consciousness**, we have already approached the threshold of understanding **why life continues**.

**Namaste!**